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New driving law aims to make roadways safer for bicyclists

BY KENT JACKSON (STAFF WRITER)

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A law that starts today requires motorists to stay 4 feet from bicyclists when passing them and might serve as well to educate drivers as to prosecute them, advocates for safe highways said.

Like laws that prohibit texting while driving or require drivers to wear seat belts, the requirement to give bicyclists 4 feet of space should prompt drivers to start thinking about protecting bicyclists.

John Schubert, the founder of Bicycle PA, said most bicyclists have felt brush-pasts when the side of a passing car or the air current around the vehicle causes them to wobble and, sometimes, tip into a ditch.

"I hope the law creates a better public understanding that when a motorist overtakes a bicyclist it should not create discomfort for the bicyclist, let alone an unsafe condition or a collision," Schubert, of Coopersburg, said.

The law also reminds motorists that it is OK to cross the center line - when no vehicles are approaching from the other direction - to pass a bicycle safely, Schubert said.

Before today, Pennsylvania law instructed drivers to pass bicycles safely, but the 4-foot rule can be used in court if cases arise from collisions between motor vehicles and bicycles.

"There is a clear standard where the police judge if the motorist was passing safely," Alex Doty, executive director of the Bicycle Coalition of Greater Philadelphia, said.

Now the Pennsylvania Department of Transportation can expect people taking exams for driver's licenses to know that they must allow 4 feet when passing bicycles, just as they must know, for example, that parking is prohibited within 20 feet of an intersection.

PennDOT should use about 14 percent of its education budget to promote safety for bicyclists and pedestrians, who account for about that percentage of deaths on roads in Pennsylvania, Doty said.

"The long-term message is about how we need to accommodate bicyclists (and) about trying to make our streets safer," Doty said.

Bicyclists play a role in their own safety and in cooperating with motorists, as indicated by a provision in the new law that requires them to make reasonable efforts to avoid impeding traffic.

As more people ride bicycles, drivers become accustomed to them.

Doubling the bicycles on a road reduces the risk of one of them getting in a crash by about one-third, said Doty, who noted that the number of bicyclists in Philadelphia quadrupled in the last decade.

Across the country, Pennsylvania joins at least 21 other states that say drivers must give bicyclists 3 feet or more space when passing. Those laws have the support of the League of American Bicyclists in Washington, D.C., Darren Flusche, the league's policy director, said by email.

Even in states such as Idaho, where a safe-passing bill died last month, advocates for safety used the debate about the bill to make drivers more aware that they have to share the road.

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Discussion

Community



marcc100 • 6 months ago

The Reason most don't ride on the sidewalk is because pedestrians use the sidewalk. Its easier to ride with traffic turn signals lane designations for going straight turning break lights make cars predictable. Pedestrians do not have any predictability. Also there are dangers of hitting pedestrians and harming them when riding on a sidewalk at speeds between 13 to 25mph. You wouldn't drive a car on the sidewalk , cause it is illegal. In many jurisdictions its illegal to operate a bicycle on the sidewalk also after age 12.

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CranberryJoe • 6 months ago

Gee whiz, how about bicycle paths? Or how about banning all cars on trucks from the highways and roads on alternate week days? Or how about making the right hand lanes for bicycles only? Good golly Miss Molly, the inmates are running the asylum.

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prouduscitizen • 6 months ago

I never understood why the bicyclists ride on the road if there is enough room on the berm or sidewalk.

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